

FROM STUDENT TO PROFESSIONAL:

Unlocking High-Retention Talent Pipelines through Professional Identity

A White Paper Prepared for the HireUTRGV Employer Summit

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Today's employers face a dual challenge: navigating intense labor market volatility while struggling to find day-one-ready talent. This white paper reframes workforce readiness for University of Texas Rio Grande Valley (UTRGV) students — a distinct demographic that is over 91% Hispanic and 67% first-generation college student — through the lens of **Professional Identity Formation** (PIF). PIF is the psychological catalyst that transforms a task-oriented student into a proactive, high-performing professional.

While UTRGV grads possess exceptional baseline competencies — including native bilingualism, proven resilience, and deep community experience — a critical gap remains. Students often lack the specific [professional socialization](#) and coaching needed to translate these real-world strengths into 'corporate language' and evidence of relevant experience. By addressing this skills perception gap and adapting to modern AI fluency demands, this paper outlines how targeted, developmental partnerships between employers and higher education can bridge the divide. Through applied projects and early engagement, employers can move beyond traditional hiring constraints to unlock a fiercely loyal, culturally agile, and high-retention talent pipeline.

Disclaimer: The thoughts and opinions expressed in this white paper are solely my own and do not represent the official position, views, or policies of my employer, UTRGV.



INTRODUCTION

I work with the future workforce long before they ever submit a job application. As a psychology lecturer teaching foundational and advanced courses — including research methods, statistics, psychometrics, human development, and introductory psychology — I guide students during the critical [developmental window](#) between the college classroom and their careers.

I do not just teach college students, however — I also study them. My expertise lies in [cognitive development](#) and [professional identity formation](#) (PIF) — the internal psychological shift where a student stops focusing on completing tasks for a grade and starts thinking, acting, and owning the mindset of a working professional. Combined with [my research into first-generation college students](#), this framework allows me to highlight the unique strengths and structural barriers UTRGV students navigate, thereby reframing common employer assumptions and advancing an evidence-based case for a deeper, more intentional university-employer partnership.

The Key Takeaway: Many UTRGV students are not underprepared in character or motivation. They are simply under-coached in how to convert their rich classroom, family, work, and community experiences into compelling professional evidence.

THE UTRGV STUDENT PROFILE

Effective employer partnerships with institutions of higher education begin with an accurate, data-driven understanding of a college or university's student population. Most UTRGV students are not 'typical' college students; thus, recruiting strategies calibrated strictly to national norms will systematically underperform in this market. The table below captures [four institutional realities](#) that define our talent ecosystem.



Statistic	Institutional Reality	Implication for Employer Partnership
91%+	Hispanic students	Fluency in two languages and cultures is the standard here, providing immediate, built-in communication assets for your teams.
93%+	From the Rio Grande Valley	A loyal, localized talent pool. Because most graduates choose to stay in the region, investing in them solves long-term corporate turnover.
~67%	First-generation college students	Immensely resilient. While they may lack legacy corporate networks, they possess high adaptability and yield an incredible return on early professional coaching.
34,000+	Enrolled students	A massive, high-performing regional talent pool. Standard, passive recruiting strategies miss them entirely, leaving a massive competitive edge for active partners.

This shifts the entire conversation around employability. A graduate who struggles to market their skills isn't underqualified—they are simply under-translated. The solution isn't basic remediation; it is Professional Identity Formation (PIF). This structured mindset shift gives students the professional clarity and confidence they need to step out of the classroom and deliver immediate business value.

EVIDENCE-BASED CHALLENGES

Navigating today's workforce requires moving past outdated hiring assumptions. The six metrics highlighted below outline the shifting labor pressures, emerging technological demands, and unique student demographics defining our regional market. Together, these data points form the foundation of the four core challenges facing early-career talent today:

42.5%	~90%	>1 in 3	3 in 4	5.2M	~67%
Underemployment rate for recent U.S. graduates, late 2025 (Fed Reserve Bank of NY)	Employers seeking explicit evidence of problem-solving ability (NACE Job Outlook 2026)	Entry-level roles now including explicit AI skill requirements (NACE 2026)	Employers more likely to hire candidates with applied/internship experience (NACE)	Projected net new U.S. jobs, 2024–2034, healthcare leading (BLS)	UTRGV students who are first-generation college graduates

Core Challenge 1: A Labor Market Demanding Accelerated Professional Maturity

- *The Data:* The Federal Reserve Bank of New York [reported](#) that recent graduate unemployment rose to 5.8% in Q1 2025, while underemployment reached 42.5% in late 2025 — the highest rate since 2020.
- *The Student Response:* Students are responding rationally to these volatile market signals. Their priorities have shifted toward stability, mentorship, and visible advancement pathways.
- *The PIF Lens:* The pragmatism evident among UTRGV students reflects structural economic pressure, not a lack of ambition. For many, the animating question is whether a role can support individual advancement alongside family obligations. Early professional socialization helps these students align their deep personal values with an employer's organizational goals.

Core Challenge 2: A Skills Perception Gap That Is Frequently Misdiagnosed

- *The Data:* NACE's [Job Outlook 2026](#) reports that nearly 90% of employers prioritize problem-solving ability, 80% expect strong teamwork skills, and over 70% value written communication, initiative, and work ethic.
- *The Divide:* NACE's competency-gap analysis documents a significant perception divide: employers consistently rate new graduates lower than students rate themselves on leadership, professionalism, and critical thinking.
- *The PIF Lens:* This gap is not a student deficit; it is a translation problem. Students regularly practice these competencies in rigorous coursework, caregiving roles, and community engagement, but they haven't been coached to see themselves as professionals yet. Because they lack that professional identity, they struggle to name, document, and demonstrate these skills in the behavioral language employers use during interviews.

Core Challenge 3: An AI Literacy Divide in Professional Formation

- *The Data:* [NACE 2026](#) data indicate that more than one-third of entry-level roles now explicitly include AI skill requirements, and employers frequently assign AI-driven tasks to current interns.
- *The Friction:* Students receive conflicting signals: higher education frequently frames AI as an academic integrity risk, while the contemporary workplace demands it as a core productivity tool.

- *The PIF Lens:* Moving a student from passive AI familiarity to practiced, ethical AI fluency is a cornerstone of modern professional identity. A student sees AI as a shortcut to get a grade; a professional sees AI as a co-pilot to optimize workflow. Aligning faculty pedagogical frameworks with employer expectations on this issue is a critical area where I have personally focused significant curricular and assignment design efforts.

The Key Takeaway: The AI era makes human skills more important, not less. Where AI assumes responsibility for routine production, employers will require graduates who possess the professional identity to formulate better questions, evaluate outputs critically, communicate with diverse stakeholders, and exercise ethical judgment.

Core Challenge 4: Skills-Based Hiring That Raises the Evidence Bar

- *The Data:* Research from [Burning Glass Institute and Lightcast](#) documents a sustained shift away from degree-based screening and toward more explicit skill requirements in job postings.
- *The Standard:* The World Economic Forum's [Future of Jobs Report 2025](#) identifies analytical thinking, resilience, technological literacy, and creative thinking as the most valued durable competencies through 2030.
- *The PIF Lens:* This shift does not diminish the value of a university degree; it means graduates must be able to make their learning outcomes legible through professional portfolios, applied projects, and work samples rather than transcripts alone. Developing a professional identity means learning to curate evidence of one's own capabilities.

EVIDENCE-BASED OPPORTUNITIES

Fortunately, the data behind these market pressures also highlights a clear path forward. By focusing on professional identity formation, employers can leverage three specific opportunities to build dependable, high-retention talent pipelines.

1. First-Generation Students as a High-Retention Talent Asset

- *Inherent Strengths:* [Grit](#), bilingual and [bicultural fluency](#), deep community commitment, and intense motivation for upward mobility are documented psychological strengths of first-generation students.

- *The Business Case:* Employers who invest in helping students translate these life assets into workplace competencies will unlock a fiercely loyal, high-performing talent pool that passive recruiting strategies miss entirely.
- *Sustained Touchpoints:* NACE research confirms that employers who build multiple early touchpoints—rather than relying on a single annual career fair appearance—develop significantly stronger, more reliable pipelines.

2. High-Growth Sectors Aligned With Regional Strengths

- *Market Growth:* The Bureau of Labor Statistics [projects](#) approximately 5.2 million net new U.S. jobs between 2024 and 2034, with healthcare and social assistance leading the expansion.
- *UTRGV Alignment:* These fast-growing occupations — including data scientists, information security analysts, and healthcare managers — map directly onto UTRGV's academic strengths.
- *Retention Opportunity:* Given local demand, behavioral health, public service, and technology-enabled human services offer a perfect fit for graduates who want to remain in the Rio Grande Valley. Employers who engage with students during their professional identity formation can secure early talent commitments and capture this regional retention advantage.

3. Applied Learning as the Engine of Professional Identity

- *The Catalyst:* NACE data indicate that more than 3 in 4 employers are more likely to hire candidates who completed internships, held leadership roles, or engaged in applied, community-based projects.
- *Removing Barriers:* Traditional internships often create structural barriers for first-generation and working students due to unpaid structures or inflexible scheduling. Short, applied micro-projects — such as data audits, bilingual outreach designs, or client communication simulations — represent an empirically grounded alternative.
- *The Classroom Bridge:* As an instructor, I can intentionally design course assignments to serve as authentic professional artifacts. The academic curriculum remains an underutilized employer partnership tool, and I am actively working to close that gap.

PRACTICAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR EMPLOYER PARTNERS

The following recommendations are grounded in NACE, WEF, and higher education research on employer-university partnership. Each represents a low-cost, high-return point of intervention that treats partnership as long-term talent development rather than mere talent extraction.

Engage Earlier and Demystify the Corporate Space: Brief class visits, 'day-in-the-life' media, and career-pathway panels lower the psychological barriers to participation for first-generation students. Students require multiple exposures before they can visualize themselves in a professional space and act on an opportunity.

Make Implicit Professional Expectations Explicit: Workplace norms that appear self-evident to employers—interview follow-up etiquette, navigating corrective feedback, or proactive communication—function as a form of '[hidden professional capital](#)'. First-generation students have the capacity, but may not have had the exposure, to acquire these norms. They are entirely teachable, but they must be taught explicitly.

Create Project-Based and Micro-Internship Pathways: Short, applied projects give employers a low-risk mechanism for talent identification while giving students critical practice in a professional role without the logistical friction of a traditional internship. Paid opportunities should be prioritized, as financial constraints remain a major barrier to participation.

Invest in [Developmental Feedback](#), Not Just Final Evaluation: Professional identity formation is an iterative process that unfolds through repeated cycles of exposure, practice, feedback, and reflection. A single capstone hiring event cannot replace this shared work. Feedback-rich hiring processes and transparent advancement pathways signal to students that you view them as long-term investments, which dramatically increases both application rates and long-term workforce retention.

CONCLUSION

An ample body of research provides the empirical and theoretical foundations for the central argument of this white paper: workforce readiness is developmental rather than binary. Students are not simply 'ready' or 'not ready'; they exist on a continuum of professional identity formation

shaped by accumulated exposure, [deliberate practice](#), and [structured feedback](#). The most distinctive scholarly contribution I bring to this conversation is this developmental frame: professional identity is not a credential to be conferred, but a psychological process to be supported. Both universities and employers bear a shared, co-responsible role in sustaining that process across the transition from student to professional.

The Key Takeaway: Students do not become career-ready simply by accumulating discrete, disconnected skills. They become career-ready when they can integrate experiences, competencies, and aspirations into a coherent professional sense of self that employers can recognize, trust, and retain.

To employers, I offer this final, highly actionable insight: **the talent you are searching for is already here.** UTRGV students are bilingual, community-rooted, intensely pragmatic, and highly motivated. What they lack is not raw capacity—it is explicit coaching in how to make that capacity visible in the language and formats that corporate ecosystems recognize. The employers who will win the war for talent in the RGV and beyond are those who do not wait for polished professionals to arrive fully formed. They are the leaders who actively partner with UTRGV and other higher education institutions to help students recognize, practice, and demonstrate the professional identity they are capable of achieving. I believe deeply that the partnership between UTRGV and our regional employer community is one of the most consequential levers available for economic mobility and workforce optimization, and I welcome the opportunity to build it with you.

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About the Author

Manuel G. Saldivar was born and raised in Brownsville, Texas. He holds bachelor's and master's degrees from the University of Texas and two doctorates from the University of Colorado. He has been a research scientist, scientific consultant, and post-secondary educator for almost thirty years. He likes to read science fiction and play chess.

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